

Photo by TITAN



Photo by VINTAGE WATCH COMPANY

brand Fabergé, which had been re-launched in 2009.

Sean Gilbertson, who led Gemfields' strategy and served as CEO of Fabergé since 2007 till 2023, recalls the watch industry landscape then: "When we began rebuilding Fabergé's watchmaking offering in 2012, the horological ecosystem was still quite compartmentalised. Serious watchmaking was largely defined by mechanical complexity and convention, while colour and gemstones (particularly in women's watches), were too often treated as decoration added after the horological idea had been resolved. We believed there was an opportunity to bring those worlds together. Fabergé's heritage is one of ingenuity, wit, movement, exceptional craftsmanship and, above all, surprise. Our watches therefore needed to be mechanically credible, but also emotionally engaging and unmistakably joyful."

Gemfields' influence on the broader watch and jewellery industry has operated at both ends of the value chain. Through their mining operations, they brought dependable volumes of emeralds and rubies to market, giving designers and manufacturers greater confidence to plan collections around colour. At the same time, sustained consumer marketing, collaborations with leading designers and the visibility afforded by Fabergé helped move these gemstones beyond the trade and into the wider cultural conversation. "Supply without desire is simply inventory," explains Gilbertson, "desire without reliable supply is an unfulfilled promise. Bringing the two together helped emeralds and rubies move from the periphery of design towards centre stage."

Beyond Fabergé

When did watch brands globally return to the use of hardstones and precious gems? "I can chart the return of colour exactly," answers Silver. "It was 2020, when Rolex produced a collection of pop, party-coloured dials just before the global lockdown. And in the last year or so, coloured stones have come back very heavily in the Rolex Day-Date, along with off-catalogue pieces, million-pound watches, heavily gem-set, wonderfully playful. You see Messi wearing bright pink sapphires; there are inks and pale blues, colours you wouldn't traditionally associate with men's watches, being worn by men everywhere. Watches are now more in tune with fashion, art and culture than they have ever been."